adjoining areas of NEFA with probable thrust lines and force levels. General Thimayya shared this appreciation with Menon. He followed up with a visit in 1960 to study the Alpine Troops of Europe and on his return gave a proposal to the Government of India to immediately raise specialized mountain divisions for the Indo-Tibet border. But when the recommendations based on Exercise Sheel and Thorat's assessment reached Menon, he shelved them, taking them up only after much prodding. He asked Thimayya to explain the rationale for such a large force as only small numbers had hitherto been involved in the isolated border clashes. The COAS duly did so, only to have Menon declare that it was 'too much' and it needed to be 'pruned down'. Thimayya resisted. And Menon's stance changed from discussion to confrontation.

Krishna Menon was also peeved with Thimayya because he had expressed his unhappiness about the preferential treatment being meted out to Kaul and certain other appointments. Kaul had been promoted to the rank of lieutenant general and brought to Delhi as the Quarter Master General (QMG) in July 1957 against the wishes of Thimayya.

## HEAD IN THE SAND

Ever since the Chinese crackdown on the Tibetans in Lhasa and the subsequent escape of the Dalai Lama to India, public opinion in India had been slowly turning against the Chinese. The prime minister's revelations in Parliament on 28 August about China's incursions and establishment of control over the Aksai Chin region further added to the ill-feeling. Angry diplomatic notes continued to buzz between Peking and New Delhi: the Chinese said that the Dalai Lama had been abducted by Chinese rebels and whisked off to India, while the Indians said he was a free man and could go where he liked provided he did not indulge in political activities.

The Khenzemane and Longju incidents in NEFA had added fuel to the fire but in all the clashes so far, there hadn't been any serious casualties on either side. This was to change drastically within the next few days.

On 20 October 1959, the focus shifted dramatically from NEFA to Ladakh when two members of an Indian Police party under Havildar Karam Singh went out on a patrol in the neighbourhood of the Kongka Pass and failed to return by the evening. A search party during the night failed to make contact with the two missing men, so another party was assembled the next morning. According to a note given by the Ministry of External Affairs